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PH2277: Philosophy and Games
24 April 2023

The Game-Maker's Dilemma:

Evaluation of Agency as Art

Whether games are art has been a point of contention among philosophers; however, the fictional, narrative and visual aesthetic properties of videogames have pushed a general consensus that videogames can be considered art (Tavinor). Nguyen argues that the attribution of these properties as the artistic value of a game is a misstep that removes from what makes games a distinct form of art – the "temporary agencies… and temporary ends" (5) offered to us by engaging in games. Considering agency as a form of art poses some problems for the broader field of the philosophy of art. For instance, the question of how to interpret art shifts: the interactive nature of videogames results in a multitude of narratives across playthroughs, and much debate in the field has centered around how to not only settle on a singular narrative without erasing essential parts of the storyline (Willis; Fisher).

Less discussed is the problem agency as art poses for the *evaluation* of art. Classic theories of the evaluation of art emphasize a lack of subjectivity while regarding an artwork – which is, of course, made difficult in the case of games where the agency itself demands an injection of the self, our desires and our strategies into its art. In the following paper, I posit that there is a serious case to be made for impossibility of evaluating the art of agency in games precisely due to the nature of such an art. Further, I attempt to defend this claim against some objections for the evaluation of the agency of art.

Evaluation of Art

Let me begin by clarifying what is meant by the evaluation of art: it is simply an assessment of whether something is a good representation of what it means to be art. In other

words, it is the ability to notice properties of something and judge how well that something fits into the category of 'being an artwork'. This is a different concept from 'interpretation' that I mentioned earlier: interpretation involves the analysis of meaning subscribed to something, whereas evaluation (though inclusive of) goes beyond meaning to assess the value of something as an artwork.

Evaluating artistic value is a difficult undertaking precisely because what makes something 'good' or 'bad' art is seemingly quite arbitrary. It is easy to evaluate what is a good bottle, for example – something that can store liquid and allow it to be emptied or filled easily without spilling. In the case of a bottle, we are *functionalists* in equating the definition of a bottle as a functional device for us to drink water as its value. This functionalism crumbles as we venture into the categories of both art and games: it is difficult enough to ascertain what the definitions of art or games are in the first place without the added conflict of reducing them to their functions. After all, a urinal on a pedestal (see Figure 1) can make an artistic statement of great value without being at all aesthetic.



Figure 1. Fountain by Marcel Duchamp, 1917.

The problem becomes that outside of the functionalist evaluation of objective properties like lines in a painting or the composition of a lyric, artistic value is subjective to the evaluator. That is, whether something is a good work of art or not seems to depend on whether it is pleasing to the perceiver. However, there still seems to be a certain universal (if not unanimous) objectivity in evaluating art – for instance, there are games that are generally lauded as brilliant, like 'The Legend of Zelda', and comparing it to, say, 'Leisure Suit Larry' would merit some sort of ridicule in public. Moreover, there do exist ranking systems like Metacritic and GameSpot that show favorable trends by a majority of players towards particular games but not to others. Thus, though there is subjectivity in evaluating art and games, it is not so pervasive that it erodes objectivity.

Frameworks for the evaluation of art have responded to this problem by laying down some criterion to prevent the mistaking one's own subjective experience as the product of the artwork's artistic value. One of the earliest frameworks of the evaluation of art, 'Of the Standard of Taste' (Hume), proposes that there are a group of true judges who decide the standard of taste and beauty. Among other characteristics, the true judges are critics who must be "free from all prejudice… and forget, if possible, my individual being and my peculiar circumstances" in evaluating art (#21). Kant, on the other hand, appeals to a more egalitarian universal claim to beauty by all people in lieu of a select group of judges. However, this beauty must be "non-conceptual" in that it should not appeal to a desire to *use* the object as means to an end (like money) and the evaluators should be "independent of interest" in that their personal desires to interact with, own, listen, or watch the artwork should not factor into their judgement (Kant 270–72).

The lack of personal bias criterion has worked well for the artworks Hume and Kant were familiar with, that had formal characteristics – such as colour and brushstrokes in paintings, assonance and rhyme in poetry, narrative and themes in novels, framing and acting

in cinema, facades and structure in architecture, notes and rhythms in music, and so on – which could be viewed within themselves without any reference to the person experiencing them. This is not to say the experience is objective. As I have mentioned, the evaluation of art must dip into the subjective experience of our perception; however, it is possible to restrict the self from the bias and focus on the formal characteristics of the referent artwork. This restriction is not possible in the case of games.

The Evaluation of Agency as Art

So far, I have laid the basis of the evaluation of art in the field of aesthetics and further claimed that games, if taken to be art, pose a serious problem to the framework of art evaluation due to the impossibility of maintaining objectivity in gameplay. Though games, especially video games, have formal characteristics as part of their medium through visual, narrative or even auditory inputs, the primary mode of games is, of course, interactive. Games rely on us to engage our own decision-making to overcome an obstacle or reach a goal. And it certainly seems to go against the grain of the theories of evaluation of art, that emphasize non-bias, to be able to evaluate games that rely on our engagement.

This problem takes on an especially difficult mode when confronted with Nguyen's claim that the art of video games, beyond its interactive features, is in the agency it offers to the players. If the experience of listening to sounds is made aesthetic through music, the experience of agency is made aesthetic through the alternate agency and disposable goals provided to us by games (18). Though Nguyen's claim is not exempt from certain qualifications, for the purposes of this paper, I believe that his argument for agency as an art is what makes games a distinctive form of art in itself. However, the problem of the evaluation of games as art doubles with this acceptance: if the interactive features of games makes evaluating them objectively impossible, then how does one confront evaluating the art of agency?

It is difficult to reconcile these two claims that first, the evaluation of art requires a degree of objectivity (Hume; Kant) and second, games are art because of the form of agency they provide us (Nguyen) with the intuition that it is not possible to be objective about the artistic value of something one is an active agent in. To illustrate, the agency of the player in 'Doki Doki Literature Club', a subversive dating game that turns into a horrific narrative on the suffering of young girls, is characterized by the player's eventual loss of control over the game happenings. The player who clicks on the game to play a simple dating-simulation plays for the experience of being able to date these girls. He may be able to evaluate the game for its animation or ending, but he fails to evaluate the artistic value of agency in the game – precisely because to aesthetically appreciate the artistic value of alternate agency, you have to *want* that agency to begin with.

One might object that I have previously mentioned that there are some universal agreements about good games, like 'Zelda', and bad games like 'Leisure Suit' – surely these contradict the idea that there are no objective agreements about games? I concede that there are objective agreements about games. However, I am here arguing for the evaluation of games as *artworks of agency*, not games as something one merely plays. Just because a bottle can be agreed upon to be good if it can store its liquid well, it does not become a good artwork for the same reason. It may also be argued that agency can easily be evaluated in its scope – a game such as 'Tetris', where players simply choose where randomized puzzle pieces are placed, grants limited agency to its players as compared to 'Monopoly Deal', where each turn involves sophisticated decision-making and strategizing against many other players along with the choice of where to place their cards. This objection, too, makes the same mistake as the previous one: it only takes into account the evaluation of agency, not agency as an art. It may well be that the experience of agency in Tetris is made more

fulfilling *because* gaining points is so difficult when one cannot control the pieces that will be encountered next.

Conclusion

I have, through this paper, laid the foundations of an argument against the possibility of evaluating games as artworks of agency. The dilemma that philosophers must face is reconciling the current theoretical frameworks of the evaluations of art that require a measure of objectivity for universal appreciation with the fact that objectivity is purposely manipulated by game-makers to achieve an active engagement that is the very essence of art in videogames.

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